

Quine and Strawson — Solved Answer-Writing Workbook and Toolkit

Ten verified PYQs and six original solved answers

Every model answer is independent learner practice and is never an official UPSC key. Exact verified wording is used for all ten primary-owned PYQs through 2026. Cross-links do not inflate ownership.

CONTENTS

Page numbers are generated from the final layout. PDF bookmarks include finer subheadings.

Demand map and locked timed bands	3	9. 2025 Q4(b) · 15 marks	14
Reusable answer spine	3	10. 2026 Q3(a) · 20 marks	15
1. 2018 Q1(e) · 10 marks	3	Original solved practice	16
2. 2018 Q2(c) · 15 marks	4	Original 1 · 10 marks	16
3. 2019 Q1(e) · 10 marks	6	Original 2 · 10 marks	17
4. 2020 Q3(b) · 15 marks	7	Original 3 · 15 marks	18
5. 2021 Q3(b) · 15 marks	8	Original 4 · 15 marks	19
6. 2021 Q3(c) · 15 marks	9	Original 5 · 20 marks	20
7. 2023 Q4(a) · 20 marks	11	Original 6 · 20 marks	22
8. 2024 Q4(c) · 15 marks	12	Final self-check	23

Demand map and locked timed bands

Marks	Suggested time	Locked answer band	Required movement
10	7–8 minutes	150–200 words	define, derive, qualify, verdict
15	10–11 minutes	250–300 words	thesis, mechanism, evaluation, qualified close
20	14–15 minutes	340–400 words	multi-limb argument, objection/reply, developed judgement

Reusable answer spine

DIRECTIVE -> PRECISE THESIS -> DOCTRINAL MECHANISM -> TEXT/EXAMPLE
-> OBJECTION -> QUALIFICATION -> DEMAND-SPECIFIC VERDICT

Do not merge Quine's naturalized holism with Strawson's descriptive metaphysics. In comparison answers, name the shared pressure and then restore the difference in method, unit of analysis and ambition.

1. 2018 Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he explain " — an argument is required, not a definition
Core issue	That "person" is logically primitive, and why that follows from the way P-predicates work
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the predicate matrix, the argument, both rivals in one sentence each
Ideal thesis	A person is a single subject of two predicate-classes, and the concept cannot be assembled from either half
Non-negotiables	M- and P-predicates with examples; "without observation"; both dualism and no-ownership named

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson explains the person not as a compound of mind and body but as a **logically primitive** concept — the concept of a single subject to which both bodily and mental predicates are ascribed, presupposed by rather than assembled from the concepts of mind and body (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

The predicate matrix. ✅ A person is that to which we ascribe both **M-predicates**, also true of mere bodies and **P-predicates**, ascribing states of consciousness. Both classes belong to **one** thing.

The argument. I can self-ascribe P-predicates only if the same predicates are ascribable to **others**; others are identified as **embodied subjects** on public behavioural criteria; yet the same predicates are self-ascribed **without observation** of my own behaviour. ⚠️ That dual character cannot be built from a pure consciousness, which never reaches public criteria, or from a pure body, which never reaches unobserved self-ascription. Its subject must already be both.

The two rivals. This undercuts **Cartesian dualism**, which cannot re-identify an immaterial soul in the framework identification requires, and destroys the **no-ownership theory**, which must say "the experiences **had by** this body" and so restores the possession it denied.

Qualification. ⚠️ "Primitive" means conceptual priority within our scheme, not a third substance.

Measured model-answer words: 199

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the directive is "how does he explain", so the six-step argument, not the definition, is the answer.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, 150 to 200 words: thesis one line; matrix two; argument four; rivals two; qualification one.

- **Structure:** thesis → matrix → argument → two rivals → qualification.
- **Doctrine:** primitiveness; the dual character of P-predicates.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; four predicate examples; the possessive "had by".
- **Distinction:** conceptual priority against substance-postulation.
- **Criticism:** implicit in the qualification, which blocks both the dualist and the materialist misreading.

2. 2018 Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he show " plus "give reasons" — a mechanism, then its grounds
Core issue	That the phrase is the paper's framing and that Quine's case is three connected moves
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: three moves, one Kantian reply, one graded verdict; not a Kant exposition
Ideal thesis	Explication failure, holism and naturalism jointly leave the a priori asserted rather than shown

Element	Requirement
Non-negotiables	The framing flagged; the 1951 dating; "no statement is immune to revision"; the Kantian reply

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. ⚠️ "A metaphysical article of faith" is the **question's framing**, not a verified verbatim Quine formula; what Quine supplies is a three-step case that a Kantian a priori is asserted rather than established.

Move one — the explication fails. Kant's synthetic a priori presupposes a workable analytic/synthetic boundary. In "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) Quine shows that analyticity can be explained only through **synonymy**, and synonymy only through **definition**, which records an antecedent synonymy; or **interchangeability *salva veritate***, which over-generates extensionally and requires a necessity-operator whose intelligibility rests on analyticity; or Carnap's **semantical rules**, which yield "analytic-in-L" without explaining the general notion. Every route returns to its starting point.

Move two — holism. Because statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body", **any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere**, and **no statement is immune to revision**. Apparent apriority is therefore greater **centrality** in the web — a difference of degree, not of kind.

Move three — naturalism. Philosophy is continuous with science and there is no first-philosophy standpoint from which a priori knowledge could be certified. To assert it is to take on trust what cannot be shown.

Objection and reply. ? Kant may answer that transcendental conditions of experience are not empirical hypotheses inside the web, so revisability does not reach them — a reply Strawson's descriptive reading of Kant supports. Quine's rejoinder is that this reasserts precisely the privileged non-empirical status in dispute.

Verdict. ⚠️ Quine defeats a **sharp** a priori/a posteriori boundary; what survives is a gradient of entrenchment, and whether some framework role escapes the web remains open.

Measured model-answer words: 276

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question is about **Quine's** argument; Kant appears as its target and as one reply, never as an exposition.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, 250 to 300 words: thesis two lines; move one six; move two four; move three two; objection two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** framing flagged → three moves → reply → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** circle of explication; holism; naturalism.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); both canonical sentences; the three failed routes.
- **Distinction:** degree of entrenchment against difference in kind.
- **Criticism:** the transcendental-conditions reply, reported as unsettled.

3. 2019 Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... arguments" — plural, so the chain must be reproduced
Core issue	The circularity of every candidate explication, and the exact conclusion drawn
Scope boundary	Ten marks: two classes, three routes, conclusion, one objection
Ideal thesis	No non-circular explication is available, so the distinction cannot bear foundational weight
Non-negotiables	The heart/kidney case; the necessity regress; "analytic-in-L"; Grice and Strawson

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Quine argues that the distinction admits no principled, **non-circular** criterion: every proposed explanation of "analytic" presupposes a notion from the same family.

The two classes. ✓ Analytic truths were said to be either **logically true** or convertible into logical truths by substituting **synonyms**. The second class therefore needs synonymy.

Three routes, three failures. **Definition** merely *records* a synonymy already present in the language, except where frankly stipulative. **Interchangeability *salva veritate*** over-generates in an extensional language — "creature with a heart" and "creature with a kidney" interchange without being synonymous — and repairing it by demanding interchange within "necessarily" presupposes a **necessity** intelligible for Quine only through analyticity. **Semantical rules** deliver "analytic-in-L" by stipulation, leaving the general notion no clearer than what it was to explain.

Conclusion. ⚠ Not that "All bachelors are unmarried" is false, but that explications fail to secure the **sharp foundational boundary** logical empiricism required. What replaces it is **degrees of entrenchment** in the web of belief.

Objection and reply. ? Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) reply that a distinction with agreed application is not discredited by the absence of a reductive analysis. Quine's rejoinder: agreed sorting is not the principled ground the positivist meaning-criterion needed.

Measured model-answer words: 199

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the marks are in the **circle**, so each route must be shown returning to synonymy or necessity.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, 150 to 200 words: thesis one line; classes two; routes five; conclusion two; objection two.

- **Structure:** thesis → two classes → three routes → exact conclusion → objection.
- **Doctrine:** synonymy, definition, *salva veritate*, semantical rules.
- **Evidence:** the heart/kidney counter-case; "analytic-in-L"; the 1956 reply.
- **Distinction:** failure of explication against falsity of the sentences.
- **Criticism:** Grice and Strawson, with the rejoinder rather than a bare mention.

4. 2020 Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Evaluate the role" — a function must be identified, then assessed
Core issue	That a single spatio-temporal framework is the condition of objective identification
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the argument, the auditory test, the limitation
Ideal thesis	Spatio-temporal thinking supplies the individuating framework without which re-identification, and so objectivity, is impossible
Non-negotiables	Identification → re-identification → framework; the three defects; the analogue of space

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Spatio-temporal thinking is not one feature of objective thought among others: it supplies the **single framework** without which particulars cannot be re-identified, and without re-identification there is no objective reference at all.

The argument. ✓ In *Individuals* (1959, Part I) Strawson argues that to identify a particular I must distinguish it from others and **re-identify** it across time; re-identification requires **one unified spatio-temporal framework** in which every particular has a location; and **material bodies**, as enduring and publicly observable occupants of that framework, are the standard anchors of demonstrative identification. Experiences, events and sounds are **dependent** particulars, identified through their relations to persons, bodies, places and times.

Why the empiricist alternative fails. Sense-data cannot supply a framework: they are **private**, so they cannot ground public identification; **momentary**, so they cannot be re-identified; and **non-spatial**, so they cannot constitute a framework at all. Material bodies are therefore basic as a **condition of the possibility of reference**, not as a metaphysical preference.

The evaluative test. ⚠️ Strawson removes space to see what it was doing. A purely auditory world of pitch and succession cannot distinguish the same particular re-encountered from a new one exactly resembling it; objective reference there would require an **analogue of space**, reconstructed through a continuously available **master-sound**. The experiment therefore isolates the **individuating role** rather than privileging our sensory organisation.

Verdict. ⚠️ The result is transcendental in form and internal in reach: it establishes what **our conceptual scheme** requires, not that reality independently contains bodies. ❓ An empiricist may accept the analysis as conceptual geography while denying that it settles ontology — and conceding this strengthens the answer.

Measured model-answer words: 266

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "evaluate the role" is answered by removing the thing whose role is in question; the auditory world is therefore the centre, not an ornament.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, 250 to 300 words: thesis two lines; argument five; failure three; test four; verdict three.

- **Structure:** thesis → argument → why sense-data fail → the removal test → limitation.
- **Doctrine:** identification, re-identification, unified framework, dependent particulars.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) Part I; the three defects; the master-sound.
- **Distinction:** individuating **role** against our particular sensory equipment.
- **Criticism:** the internal, scheme-relative reach of the conclusion.

5. 2021 Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Definition, then reasons , then "critically discuss" — three obligations
Core issue	Two kinds of basic particular, each with its own argument
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: both arguments compressed, then two objections with replies
Ideal thesis	Bodies are basic by the identification argument, persons by the dual-ascription argument
Non-negotiables	Both kinds answered; the three defects; M/P predicates; anthropocentrism and the "primitive" objection

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Basic particulars are those on which the possibility of **identification and reference in general** depends; Strawson argues that **material bodies** and **persons** occupy that role in our conceptual scheme, each by a distinct argument.

Bodies. ✅ Identification requires **re-identification**; re-identification requires a **single unified spatio-temporal framework**; and material bodies are its enduring, publicly observable occupants, anchoring demonstrative identification (*Individuals*, 1959, Part I). Sense-data cannot take the role: they are **private**, **momentary** and **non-spatial**. Experiences, events and sounds are identified only through their relations to bodies, persons, places and times.

Persons. ✅ A person is a single subject bearing both **M-predicates** — "weighs 70 kg" — and **P-predicates** — "is in pain" (ch. 3). Self-ascription of P-predicates is possible only if they are **other-ascribable** on public criteria, while remaining **self-ascribable without observation**. A predicate with that dual character cannot be constructed from a pure body or a pure consciousness, so the concept of a person is **logically primitive** — the second kind of basic particular.

Critical assessment. ❓ First, the argument is charged with **anthropocentrism**: another scheme might not need bodies. Strawson's conclusion always concerned **our** scheme, and the purely auditory discussion concedes that an **analogue of space** could perform the individuating role — a measured reply rather than a refutation. ❓ Second, calling the person concept "primitive" may **end** analysis rather than explain the psychophysical unity. Strawson's defenders answer that the demand for analysis into mind plus body already presupposes dualism, so refusal is the point; but the mechanism of unity is genuinely untouched.

Verdict. ⚠️ The reasons succeed as **descriptive metaphysics**: they establish what our scheme requires, not what exists independently of it.

Measured model-answer words: 265

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem names **two** kinds of basic particular, so an answer that argues only for bodies has answered half the question.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, 250 to 300 words: thesis two lines; bodies four; persons four; assessment five; verdict one.

- **Structure:** definition → bodies → persons → two objections with replies → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** identification/re-identification; the dual character of P-predicates.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) Part I and ch. 3; the three defects; the master-sound concession.
- **Distinction:** two different arguments for two kinds of basic particular.
- **Criticism:** anthropocentrism and the explanatory limits of "primitive".

6. 2021 Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Critically examine " — assessment must occupy a substantial share
Core issue	What empiricism retains once both dogmas are removed
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: both dogmas compressed, holism, then the objections
Ideal thesis	The dogmas are removed and empiricism survives, reformed rather than refuted
Non-negotiables	Both dogmas; "at root identical"; the pragmatic virtues; Grice–Strawson; the arbitrariness objection

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Quine's postulate is **subtraction, not replacement**: two assumptions are removed and what survives — sensory evidence and scientific naturalism — is still empiricism, now holistic and thoroughly revisable.

The two dogmas. ✅ The first is the belief in a principled analytic/synthetic boundary; it fails because **definition, interchangeability *salva veritate* and semantical rules** each presuppose synonymy, necessity or analyticity. The second is **reductionism**: the assumption that each statement has its own confirming experiences, whether by translation into a sense-datum language or by individual confirmation. ⚠️ Quine's own verdict is that the two are **at root identical**, since statements "confirmed come what may" need a contrast class of individually confirmed statements.

What replaces them. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**"; the unit of empirical significance is **the whole of science**; and revision, forced somewhere by a recalcitrant experience, is located by **simplicity, conservatism and fecundity** rather than by logic.

What survives. ✅ Experience remains the check on the system, science remains the best account of what there is, and there is **no first philosophy** outside it. The line between speculative metaphysics and natural science becomes one of **degree**.

Critical assessment. ❓ Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) object that a distinction with agreed application needs no reductive definition; Quine replies that ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy, and the dispute is really about **standards of explication**. ❓ The arbitrariness charge — if everything is revisable, nothing constrains belief — is met by pragmatic conservatism and, in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970), by the **maxim of minimum mutilation**.

Verdict. ⚠️ Holism is right about **confirmation** and overstated about **revisability**; the postulate stands in its reformed, not its most radical, version.

Measured model-answer words: 280

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critically examine" requires the assessment to be a section, not a closing sentence.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, 250 to 300 words: thesis two lines; dogmas five; replacement three; survival two; assessment four; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis → both dogmas → holism → what survives → objections → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the circle; reductionism in two forms; the corporate body; entrenchment.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956); *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **Distinction:** subtraction against rejection of empiricism.
- **Criticism:** standards of explication; the arbitrariness charge and its constraints.

7. 2023 Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A why , then an implication — two questions, both answered explicitly
Core issue	That both rival accounts presuppose the concept they try to construct or eliminate
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the frame, the argument, both rivals, a graded verdict
Ideal thesis	Person is prior to mind and body, so the dualist question is dissolved rather than answered
Non-negotiables	Descriptive frame; M/P predicates; the dual character; dualism and no-ownership; the cost

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson holds the concept of a person to be **logically primitive** because both rival accounts of the mind-body relation presuppose it; the implication for dualism is not refutation of a thesis but **dissolution of its starting point**.

The frame. ✓ *Individuals* (1959) is **descriptive metaphysics**: it describes the actual structure of our thought rather than proposing a better one. The question is therefore what our scheme of ascribing predicates to persons requires.

Why primitive. ✓ In our scheme a person is a single entity bearing both **M-predicates**, also true of mere bodies — "weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen" — and **P-predicates**, ascribing states of consciousness — "is in pain", "intends to leave". The decisive feature is the **dual character** of P-predicates: they are ascribed to **others** on publicly available behavioural and situational criteria, and to **oneself without**

observation of one's own behaviour. ⚠ From a pure consciousness one never reaches public criteria, so other-ascription is impossible; from a pure body one never reaches unobserved self-ascription. Only a subject that is already **both** satisfies both conditions, and the concept of that subject is therefore **prior** to the concepts of mind and body — "logically prior to that of an individual consciousness".

The implication for dualism. ✅ Cartesian dualism treats an independently identifiable mind and body as conceptually prior; but an immaterial soul cannot be located in the single spatio-temporal framework in which identification and **re-identification** occur, and once the two substances are separated their interaction becomes unintelligible. Strawson does not answer the interaction question — he shows that it presupposes a prior unity neither term can supply. ⚠ The **no-ownership theory** fares no better: to say which experiences are in question the theorist must say "the experiences **had by** this body", and the possessive restores the ownership he denied.

Assessment. ? The strength is economy: the problem is **dissolved** because the decomposition generating it is illicit. The cost is that "primitive" marks the **end of analysis** rather than an explanation of psychophysical unity — legitimate for descriptive metaphysics, unsatisfying for anyone who wanted the problem solved. ⚠ And the conclusion is scheme-relative: dualism's **starting point** is undercut, not every dualist thesis disproved.

Measured model-answer words: 352

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the second question is the marked one; the exposition must be arranged so that the implication is earned rather than announced.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, 340 to 400 words: thesis one line; frame two; why primitive eight; implication seven; assessment four.

- **Structure:** thesis → descriptive frame → the argument → dualism → no-ownership → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** primitiveness; predicate duality; dissolution rather than solution.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; four predicate examples; the possessive "had by".
- **Distinction:** undercutting a **starting point** against refuting every dualist thesis.
- **Criticism:** the end-of-analysis cost, conceded and correctly located.

8. 2024 Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain the nature " — what each dogma is, and what makes each a dogma
Core issue	Both dogmas defined, both refuted, and the relation between them stated

Element	Requirement
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: definitions, the refutations, the identification, one criticism
Ideal thesis	Two unargued assumptions, structurally the same, both removed by holism
Non-negotiables	Both forms of reductionism; the label explained; "at root identical"

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The two dogmas are unargued assumptions of logical empiricism — a principled analytic/synthetic boundary and sentence-by-sentence confirmation — and Quine's case is that they are **at root identical**.

The first dogma. ✓ It is the belief that there is a non-arbitrary line between statements true **by virtue of meaning** and statements true **by virtue of fact**. It is a dogma because the line cannot be drawn non-circularly: analyticity requires **synonymy**; synonymy is explained by **definition**, which merely records an antecedent synonymy, or by **interchangeability *salva veritate***, which over-generates extensionally ("creature with a heart" / "creature with a kidney") and requires a necessity-operator that presupposes analyticity, or by Carnap's **semantical rules**, which give "analytic-in-L" without explaining the general notion.

The second dogma. ✓ **Reductionism** is the belief that each meaningful statement is translatable into, or individually confirmable by, a range of sense-experience. Its **radical** form demands term-by-term translation into a sense-datum language; its **attenuated** form abandons translation but keeps individual confirmation. ⚠ The label names the operation: it *reduces* sentence-meaning to observation sentences.

Why both fall together. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**", so the unit of empirical significance is **the whole of science**. ⚠ Once no statement has its own evidential stock, the class of statements "confirmed come what may" has no contrast class — which is why Quine calls the two dogmas at root identical.

Assessment. ? Grice and Strawson (1956) object that the first distinction is intelligible in ordinary use without a reductive analysis; Quine replies that ordinary intelligibility is not the principled ground the positivist meaning-criterion required.

Verdict. ⚠ What replaces both is **empiricism without the dogmas**: holistic, revisable and still empiricist.

Measured model-answer words: 276

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "nature" asks what each dogma **is** and why it deserves the name; the identification of the two is what turns a list into an argument.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, 250 to 300 words: thesis one line; first dogma five; second dogma four; identification three; assessment two; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis → dogma one → dogma two → why they fall together → objection → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the circle; radical and attenuated reductionism; the corporate body.

- **Evidence:** the heart/kidney case; "analytic-in-L"; the unit of empirical significance.
- **Distinction:** the two forms of reductionism, and the explanation of the label.
- **Criticism:** the 1956 reply with Quine's rejoinder.

9. 2025 Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A statement question : locate the sentence in the system, then unpack it
Core issue	That the conditional clause is the doctrine, and that it is a claim about confirmation
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the mechanism, the historical illustration, the constraints, the verdict
Ideal thesis	The sentence states holistic confirmation, not licence: the cost is what disciplines the choice
Non-negotiables	<i>Modus tollens</i> ; the three revision options; Neptune and "Vulcan"; minimum mutilation

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The sentence is a claim about **where blame for a failed prediction may be assigned**, not a licence to believe anything: the clause "just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere" names the price, and the price is the doctrine.

Where it sits. ✓ It belongs to §6 of "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), after both dogmas have been removed. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**", so the unit of empirical significance is the whole of science.

The mechanism. ✓ A hypothesis entails an observation only with **auxiliaries**: the testable claim is $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$. When experience yields not-O, ***modus tollens*** delivers only not-(H & A) — H is false **or** some element of A is false — and logic never names the guilty conjunct. Three responses are therefore available: revise a peripheral belief, revise a deep interior statement, or **plead hallucination** and revise the observation itself. The third is what makes the quoted sentence literally true.

The historical illustration. ✓ Anomalies in Uranus's orbit were met by revising the auxiliary assumption about the number of planets, and **Neptune** was found (1846). The identical strategy applied to Mercury produced the hypothesised planet "**Vulcan**", which does not exist; there the correct revision was the deep one — **general relativity** (1915). ⚠ Same logical situation, opposite correct responses, no advance rule.

What blocks relativism. ⚠️ Revision is chosen on grounds of **simplicity, conservatism and fecundity**, and in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) Quine adds the **maxim of minimum mutilation** and warns that "change of logic" is change of subject. No statement is revisable **by nature**; only by choice, and choice has costs.

Verdict. ⚠️ The statement is right about confirmation and easily misread as relativism; truncating it at "come what may" is what produces the misreading.

Measured model-answer words: 297

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a statement question is failed by paraphrase; the answer must supply the mechanism the sentence compresses.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, 250 to 300 words: thesis two lines; location two; mechanism five; illustration four; constraints two; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis → location in §6 → *modus tollens* → Neptune/Vulcan → constraints → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** holistic confirmation; the three revision options.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951) §6; Neptune 1846; "Vulcan" and general relativity 1915; *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **Distinction:** re-allocating blame against indifference to evidence.
- **Criticism:** the relativist misreading identified and diagnosed.

10. 2026 Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why are states of consciousness ascribed to anything at all and why are they ascribed to the same things to which we also ascribe physical properties? How does Strawson answer these questions in his work *Individuals*?

Demand decoding

Cover Strawson asks how predicates of consciousness, same subject, self-ascription requires; close with States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson asks how predicates of consciousness can have subjects at all and why those subjects are the very individuals to whom bodily predicates apply. In *Individuals* he answers through the logically primitive concept of a **person**: one identifiable particular that is the subject of both physical or M-predicates and psychological or P-predicates.

Why states of consciousness are ascribed. A state such as pain, belief or intention is not treated as an ownerless event. Its grammar requires possible self-ascription and other-ascription. The predicate "is in pain" is self-ascribed without observing one's behaviour, yet it is also ascribed to another person through public behavioural and situational criteria. A predicate could not possess this double use if it applied only to a private ego available to one subject.

Why the same things receive physical predicates. Other persons must be identified and re-identified in the public spatio-temporal framework. The individual encountered as walking, speaking and occupying a place is the same subject who is said to hope, suffer or decide. Thus one subject bears M-predicates such as location and weight and P-predicates such as thought and sensation. The concept of a person is logically prior to separate abstractions of body and consciousness.

Argument and other minds. Self-ascription requires that predicates of the same type can be other-ascribed; other-ascription requires embodied, publicly identifiable subjects. This avoids an analogical inference from a visible body to a hidden Cartesian mind. Behaviour is criterial evidence for third-person use, not a reduction of experience to behaviour.

Implication and qualification. Cartesian dualism starts with two independently identifiable substances and then cannot explain their single subjecthood. The no-ownership theory also fails because relating a class of experiences to this body rather than another covertly restores the person. Strawson establishes conceptual priority, however, not a causal mechanism of psychophysical unity. His answer dissolves the faulty starting point more clearly than it solves every metaphysical problem of consciousness.

Verdict. States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed to the same things because the person, not an ego-body aggregate, is the primitive bearer that makes both forms of predication possible.

Measured model-answer words: 347

Why this earns marks

Qualification / criticism: The answer explicitly contains the limiting move “States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed” and does not convert a conceptual argument into a stronger ontological or causal proof.

Coverage check: Verified anchors: Strawson asks how predicates of consciousness; same subject; self-ascription requires; States of consciousness and physical properties are ascribed.

Original solved practice

The six formal-session models restore two questions at each mark level. They cover Duhem–Quine testing, descriptive metaphysics, logical revisability, no-ownership, translation indeterminacy and the two-project comparison.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why, for Quine, no single scientific hypothesis can be tested in isolation.

Demand decoding

Answer the directive through a precise thesis, the named mechanism, a criticism and a qualified verdict.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. A hypothesis makes no prediction by itself, so experience never convicts it alone; what is tested is always a **conjunction**.

The mechanism. ✓ The testable claim is $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$, where A gathers background theory, instrument theory and initial conditions. Observation yields **not-O**, and *modus tollens* delivers only **not-(H & A)**: H is false or some element of A is false. Logic does not say which.

The consequence. ⚠ A reductionist criterion assigning each statement its own confirming experiences therefore has no application — which is precisely Quine's second dogma. And symmetrically, "any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system".

The evidence. ✓ Anomalies in Uranus's orbit were resolved by revising an auxiliary, and **Neptune** was found in **1846**; the same move applied to Mercury produced "**Vulcan**", which does not exist, and the correct revision proved to be **general relativity (1915)**. Identical logical situations, opposite correct responses.

Qualification. ⚠ **Duhem (1906)** confined the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; the extension to all knowledge is Quine's own step. Nor does the thesis make revision arbitrary: simplicity, conservatism and minimum mutilation still discriminate.

Measured model-answer words: 191

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the logical form is the answer; the history is what proves it is not a mere possibility.

- **Structure:** thesis $\rightarrow$ *modus tollens* $\rightarrow$ consequence for dogma two $\rightarrow$ paired historical case $\rightarrow$ qualification.
- **Doctrine:** the conjunction under test; holistic confirmation.
- **Evidence:** Neptune 1846; "Vulcan"; general relativity 1915; Duhem 1906.
- **Distinction:** Duhem's restricted thesis against Quine's extension.
- **Criticism:** the arbitrariness worry, answered by pragmatic constraints.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish descriptive from revisionary metaphysics, and explain why Strawson describes his own project as descriptive.

Demand decoding

Answer the directive through a precise thesis, the named mechanism, a criticism and a qualified verdict.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Descriptive metaphysics describes the actual structure of our thought about the world; revisionary metaphysics proposes a better structure; Strawson maps conditions of the scheme we use.

The distinction. ✓ In *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* (1959) the descriptive metaphysician maps how our concepts hang together; the revisionary metaphysician recommends replacing them. His examples place **Aristotle** and **Kant** on the descriptive side, and **Descartes**, **Leibniz** and **Berkeley** on the revisionary side.

The relation. ⚠️ revisionary metaphysics is at its most valuable **in the service of** the descriptive, because dismantling part of the actual scheme reveals what it was doing.

Why Strawson's project is descriptive. ✓ His method is **connective analysis**: concepts are exhibited in their dependence on one another, not reduced to a privileged base of simples. His arguments are **transcendental in form** — from an undisputed fact about identification or ascription to its conditions — and their conclusions are therefore about our scheme.

Qualification. ? The programme is charged with being circular or conservative, since it protects the scheme in which its conditions are stated. Strawson accepts an **internal** task: even radical revision must begin inside some functioning scheme of identification and reference. Description still cannot show the scheme uniquely correct.

Measured model-answer words: 197

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the fatal error here is two definitions with no examples; Strawson's own names are the cheapest marks available.

- **Structure:** thesis → distinction with examples → relation → why descriptive → objection and cost.
- **Doctrine:** connective analysis; transcendental form.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) and its subtitle; Aristotle and Kant; Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley.
- **Distinction:** describing against replacing a conceptual scheme.
- **Criticism:** the conservatism charge, answered by the internality of the task.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "No statement is immune to revision." How far can this claim be sustained in the case of logic?

Demand decoding

Answer the directive through a precise thesis, the named mechanism, a criticism and a qualified verdict.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The claim can be sustained **in principle** and only weakly in practice: logic is protected by entrenchment and by the cost of revision rather than by any certificate of analyticity.

The claim and its source. ✅ It stands in §6 of "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) as the converse of "any statement can be held true come what may". The early essay extends revisability even to a law of logic, mentioning the proposed revision of the law of excluded middle as a means of simplifying quantum mechanics.

The strongest candidate. ✅ **Birkhoff and von Neumann**, "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics" (*Annals of Mathematics*, 1936), proposed a **non-distributive lattice** of quantum propositions — a formal proposal. ⚠️ The distinct philosophical claim that logic is therefore **empirically revisable**, and specifically that the **distributive law** should be given up, is **Putnam's**, in "Is Logic Empirical?" (1968). ❌ The two must never be merged into "Putnam/Birkhoff". ❓ Putnam later abandoned the position.

The resistance, from Quine himself. ⚠️ In *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) Quine argues that anyone who "denies" a law of logic has merely **changed the subject**, and he invokes the **maxim of minimum mutilation**. The later Quine is therefore a poor witness for the earlier Quine's boldest claim.

Assessment. ❓ The objection that unrestricted revisability leaves science without a fixed point is met by the formula that no statement is revisable **by nature**, only by **choice** — and choice is disciplined by conservatism, simplicity and predictive success. But the concession is substantial: if revising logic normally costs more than any theory can pay, "revisable" does little work.

Verdict. ⚠️ Holism is right about **confirmation** and overstated about **revisability**. The defensible position is Duhem's thesis with Quine's motivation: testing is holistic, the choice of revision is pragmatic, and logic is revisable in a sense so attenuated that little follows from it.

Measured model-answer words: 300

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "how far" demands a graded ruling, and the grading must be earned by the 1936/1968/1970 sequence rather than asserted.

- **Structure:** thesis → source of the claim → the candidate case → Quine's own retreat → assessment → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** revisability by choice rather than by nature; minimum mutilation.
- **Evidence:** Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936; Putnam 1968 and his later withdrawal; *Philosophy of Logic* 1970.
- **Distinction:** a formal proposal against a philosophical claim about it.
- **Criticism:** the attenuation objection, conceded and priced.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Examine Strawson's criticism of the no-ownership theory of the self.

Demand decoding

Answer the directive through a precise thesis, the named mechanism, a criticism and a qualified verdict.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson's criticism is that the no-ownership theory cannot be **stated** without reinstating the ownership it denies, so it refutes itself in the act of formulation.

The theory, fairly stated. ✓ The no-ownership or **no-subject** theory — which Strawson reconstructs and criticises, tracing it through Schlick and Wittgenstein-influenced writers — holds that experiences are **causally dependent** on a particular body but are not literally **possessed** by any subject. Its motive is respectable: it avoids the Cartesian ego while acknowledging the evident dependence of experience on a body.

The criticism. ✓ To state the thesis the theorist must say **which** experiences he is discussing, and he can only say "all the experiences **that are had by** this body". "Had by" is a **possessive** relation. Contingent causal dependence cannot replace it, because dependence does not single out **these** experiences as one person's rather than another's. The framework of personal ownership therefore returns inside the denial.

The positive alternative. ✓ The reason ownership cannot be removed is that **P-predicates** — "is in pain", "believes it will rain" — must be ascribable to **others** on publicly available criteria and to **oneself without observation**. A predicate with that dual condition presupposes a single subject bearing both **M-** and **P-predicates**; the concept of that subject, the **person**, is therefore **logically primitive** (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

Assessment. ? The argument is powerful against the theory as formulated, but it is a **conceptual** result: it shows that our scheme of ascription requires an owner, not that a metaphysically ownerless psychology is incoherent in every possible description. ⚠ And "primitive" ends the analysis rather than explaining how one subject bears both predicate-classes.

Verdict. ⚠ The no-ownership theory is destroyed on its own terms; the deeper question of psychophysical unity is dissolved rather than answered.

Measured model-answer words: 285

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: state the target theory sympathetically before demolishing it; the demolition is worthless against a straw man.

- **Structure:** thesis → the theory and its motive → the possessive move → the positive alternative → assessment.
- **Doctrine:** ownership; P-predicate duality; primitiveness.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; the formula "the experiences had by this body".
- **Distinction:** causal dependence against possession.
- **Criticism:** the scheme-relative reach of the result.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's thesis of the indeterminacy of translation. Does it establish that there are no determinate meanings?

Demand decoding

Answer the directive through a precise thesis, the named mechanism, a criticism and a qualified verdict.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The thesis follows validly from Quine's premises but establishes its conclusion **only for those who already accept his naturalism**; what survives independently is the negative result that observable use does not fix reference.

The construction. ✓ In *Word and Object* (1960, ch. 2) a field linguist must build a manual for an unknown language from **assent and dissent under stimulation**. A rabbit runs past; the native says "Gavagai"; the linguist writes "Rabbit". But the same **stimulus meaning** fits "**undetached rabbit-parts**", "**a temporal stage of a rabbit**", "**rabbithood**", and the feature-placing "it's rabbiting". ⚠ He cannot simply ask whether this gavagai is the same as that one: the question presupposes a translated **identity predicate** and the whole **apparatus of individuation**, which is exactly what is in dispute.

The two results. ✓ Compensating adjustments preserve every behavioural prediction, so behavioural evidence does not determine reference — **inscrutability of reference**. Extending upward, rival **analytical hypotheses** yield manuals agreeing on all **observation sentences** while translating theoretical sentences into non-equivalent English — **indeterminacy of translation**. ⚠ There are then no determinate **meanings** as entities, so synonymy loses its anchor and the first dogma's key notion loses its foundation.

The premises where objections enter. ⚠ **P1:** behaviourism about the *evidence* — in linguistics, Quine says, one has no choice, since language is learned wholly from public behaviour. **P2:** the move from behavioural equivalence to "no further fact" is a substantive commitment. **P3:** naturalism denies any standpoint from which meanings could be certified.

The objections. ? **Chomsky** ("Quine's Empirical Assumptions", 1969): indeterminacy is merely the ordinary **underdetermination of theory by evidence**; if that does not make physics factless, why does it make translation factless? Quine replies that in physics there is a fact our theories imperfectly track, while in translation nothing beyond dispositions could make a manual right — an **asymmetry** that is a naturalist thesis rather than a result of the argument. ? **Searle and Evans:** applied reflexively it entails that I do not determinately know what I mean; Quine accepts a version — we **acquiesce in our mother tongue**. ⚠ **Davidson** ("Radical Interpretation", 1973) accepts indeterminacy but confines it to something like a choice of measurement scale — real but harmless.

Verdict. ⚠ The thesis does **not** establish that there are no meanings *tout court*; it establishes that there are no determinate meanings **as entities** fixed by behavioural evidence. The durable result is that use alone does not fix reference — a conclusion the later Wittgenstein reaches by another route.

Measured model-answer words: 400

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question contains a second, narrower question; the verdict must answer it in the terms in which it was asked.

- **Structure:** thesis → the construction → the two results → the premises → three objections → graded verdict.

- **Doctrine:** stimulus meaning; analytical hypotheses; inscrutability against indeterminacy.
- **Evidence:** *Word and Object* (1960) ch. 2; the four rival readings; Chomsky 1969; Davidson 1973.
- **Distinction:** meanings as entities against the intelligibility of meaningful use.
- **Criticism:** the behaviourist premise identified as the load-bearing one.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Quine and Strawson criticise empiricism, but they do not criticise it together." Discuss.

Demand decoding

Answer the directive through a precise thesis, the named mechanism, a criticism and a qualified verdict.

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The statement is correct: the two attack empiricism at different levels with different tools, and the only documented exchange between them is a **disagreement**.

Quine's level — confirmation. ✓ "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) removes two assumptions. The **analytic/synthetic** boundary fails because definition merely records synonymy, interchangeability *salva veritate* over-generates extensionally and requires a necessity that presupposes analyticity, and semantical rules give only "analytic-in-L". **Reductionism** fails because statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**". What replaces both is **confirmation holism**, and what survives is **empiricism without the dogmas** — sensory evidence and naturalism retained.

Strawson's level — reference. ✓ *Individuals* (1959) argues that identification requires **re-identification**, that re-identification requires a **single unified spatio-temporal framework**, and that **material bodies** are its enduring, publicly observable occupants. Sense-data cannot occupy the role: they are **private**, **momentary** and **non-spatial**. And since **P-predicates** must be other-ascribed on public criteria yet self-ascribed **without observation**, the concept of a **person** is **logically primitive**, destroying the **no-ownership** alternative as well as the Cartesian one.

Why this is not a joint critique. ⚠ The methods are opposed. Quine is a **naturalist** who regiments science into canonical notation and denies any first philosophy; Strawson practises **connective analysis** and offers arguments that are **transcendental in form**. Their conclusions differ correspondingly: Quine ends with a revisable web in which no statement is immune; Strawson ends with conditions internal to a conceptual scheme that his method is not designed to revise. ✓ And the decisive evidence is textual: **Grice and Strawson**, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956), defend the very distinction Quine attacked, arguing that a distinction with agreed application needs no reductive analysis. Quine's rejoinder — that ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy — leaves a live dispute about **standards of explication**, not a shared programme.

What may legitimately be said jointly. ⚠ Empiricism failed twice over: about how theories are **confirmed** and about how we so much as **refer**. That is a problem-field, not a thesis.

Verdict. ⚠ Read together they pressure both empiricist confirmation atomism and sense-datum reconstruction **without becoming one school**; and an answer that treats them as co-authors of a single anti-empiricist doctrine misdescribes the only exchange the record contains.

Measured model-answer words: 361

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the quoted claim must be **tested**, not illustrated; the 1956 paper is the evidence that decides it.

- **Structure:** thesis → Quine's level → Strawson's level → why not joint → the legitimate joint sentence → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** holism; identification and re-identification; primitiveness.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); *Individuals* (1959); "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956).
- **Distinction:** naturalism and regimentation against connective, transcendental analysis.
- **Criticism:** the standards-of-explication dispute, reported as unsettled.

Final self-check

- Did the answer follow the exact directive rather than merely describe the thinker?
- Did every quotation perform argumentative work?
- Did the final judgement preserve scope, ownership and the strongest limitation?
- Did a Quine answer distinguish holism, naturalism, commitment and translation doctrines?
- Did a Strawson answer distinguish basic bodies, primitive persons and the separate referring debate?